compiled, including the famous *Manusmriti* (or Laws of Manu). In addition to spiritual laws and codes of conduct, the *Manusmriti* devotes considerable attention—indeed an entire chapter—to guidance on statecraft, including norms of warfare. [14]

Indian commercial contacts with the Roman Empire, roughly contemporaneous with the Kushans, were extensive. Indeed, the Kushans may have risen to power on the back of trade with Rome, given their control over important trade routes. Roman-era traders—often described as *yavanas*, the same word used for Greeks—imported rare metals, pepper, gemstones, textiles, indigo, and ivory from India in exchange for glass, coral, frankincense, wine, and especially coins. The writer Pliny the Elder describes Roman imports from the east worth about half the Roman empire's annual coin production and Roman coins from the reigns of Augustus and Tiberius have been found across south-eastern India and in such unlikely places as near Nagpur in central India. [15] A papyrus housed at the Austrian National Library in Vienna records an agreement between a Roman-era merchant in Alexandria, Egypt and a counterpart in Muchiri (Muziris) in Kerala, an early example of a recorded and decipherable trade agreement with India. The importance of the spice trade is highlighted in Tamil Sangam literature, which describes warfare between local Indian rulers to control commercial flows. Medieval European copies of ancient maps suggest a Roman presence on the Malabar coast to manage and secure spice exports, including concerns about pirates. [16] It is little surprise that these links also saw the exchange of people, including the arrival over successive centuries of Jews and Syrian Christians on Indian shores. By tradition, St Thomas the Apostle went on a mission to India in the first century; he died and was buried in present-day Chennai.

Roman-era perspectives of India were documented by writers such as Arrian, Strabo, and Philostratus, who—based on the travels of Alexander, the admiral Nearchus, and the philosopher Apollonius—wrote of India as a source of special knowledge and luxury goods, as well as the edge of the known world. [17] Embassies from India are recorded as having visited Rome or Constantinople during the reigns of the emperors Trajan, Constantine,